



DAILY EDITORIAL SUMMARY

07th May 2026

Topics to be covered:

- ✓ **Medical Value Travel**
- ✓ **A New Road Map for Independent Cinema**
- ✓ **Ecocide and International Environmental Law**

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Topics

Medical Value Travel

GS 2: Polity & Governance

Context:

India is increasingly positioning itself as a global centre for Medical Value Travel (MVT) through the combination of advanced healthcare infrastructure and traditional wellness systems such as AYUSH.

About Medical Value Travel (MVT):

- ❖ Medical Value Travel (MVT) refers to the cross-border movement of patients for curative medical treatment and preventive wellness services.
- ❖ It combines modern healthcare with traditional wellness systems such as AYUSH to promote holistic well-being.
- ❖ According to the Medical Tourism Index 2020–21:
 - India ranks 10th among the top 46 medical tourism destinations globally
 - 12th among the world's top 20 wellness tourism markets
 - 5th among the top 10 wellness destinations in the Asia-Pacific region.

Pillars of MVT:

- ❖ **Medical Tourism (Curative Care):** Focuses on advanced medical treatment and surgeries.
 - **Major Services in India**
 - ✓ Cardiac surgeries
 - ✓ Organ transplants
 - ✓ Cancer treatment
 - ✓ Orthopaedic and neurological procedures
- ❖ **Key Features**
 - High-quality healthcare
 - Affordable treatment costs
 - Advanced medical technology
- ❖ **Wellness Tourism (Preventive Care):** Emphasises holistic health, lifestyle improvement, and preventive healthcare.
 - **Major Components:** Yoga, Ayurveda and Naturopathy

Global and Indian Market Trends:

- ❖ **Global MVT market size (2022):** Around USD 115.6 billion
- ❖ **Projected global market by 2030:** Around USD 286.1 billion
- ❖ **India's medical tourism market (2025):** Around USD 8.7 billion
- ❖ **Projected Indian market by 2030:** Around USD 16.2 billion

India's Strengths as Global MVT Hub:

- ❖ **Strong Healthcare Infrastructure:** India has over 69,000 hospitals and around 1.2 million registered doctors.
 - Meets WHO-recommended doctor-population ratio.
- ❖ **Cost-Effective Treatment:** Medical procedures are significantly cheaper compared to developed countries while maintaining quality standards.

- ❖ **Advanced Accreditation System:** Hospitals are accredited by the National Accreditation Board for Hospitals and Healthcare Providers (NABH).
- ❖ **AYUSH Advantage:** India has a unique strength in Ayurveda, Yoga, Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and Homeopathy.

Government Initiatives:

- ❖ **National Strategy for Medical Tourism:** Promotion of “Heal in India” under a coordinated national framework.
- ❖ **Liberalised Visa Regime:** e-Medical Visa and e-Medical Attendant Visa extended to citizens of 172 countries.
- ❖ **Digital Initiatives:** Revamped MVT portal for booking, payments, and post-treatment services.
 - Airport concierge and facilitation services for international patients.
- ❖ **Infrastructure Expansion:** Proposal for new All India Institutes of Ayurveda.
 - Strengthening of the WHO Global Traditional Medicine Centre at Jamnagar.

Challenges in Medical & Wellness Tourism:

- ❖ **Lack of Standardisation:** AYUSH therapies often lack globally accepted protocols and certification standards.
- ❖ **Infrastructure Gaps:** Advanced healthcare facilities remain concentrated in metropolitan cities.
- ❖ **Ethical and Regulatory Concerns:** Issues related to organ transplant ethics and malpractice risks can affect credibility.
- ❖ **Workforce Shortages:** Limited availability of trained paramedical staff, interpreters, and culturally sensitive service providers.
- ❖ **Weak Global Branding:** India’s “Heal in India” campaign remains less visible compared to countries like Thailand and Turkey.

Way Forward:

- ❖ **Standardisation of AYUSH:** Develop evidence-based protocols and internationally accepted certification systems.
- ❖ **Strengthening Accreditation:** Expand NABH coverage and ensure regular quality audits.
- ❖ **Development of Tier-2 Medical Hubs:** Promote advanced healthcare infrastructure beyond metropolitan cities.
- ❖ **Global Branding:** Aggressively promote “Heal in India” through international campaigns.
- ❖ **Integrated Digital Ecosystem:** Strengthen MVT portals for seamless treatment, booking, and follow-up care.

Mains Practice:

- Q. India's emergence as a global hub for Medical Value Travel (MVT) is hindered by regulatory gaps and lack of standardization. Analyze the challenges and suggest measures to strengthen the 'Heal in India' initiative. (150 Words, 10 Marks)

A New Road Map for Independent Cinema

GS II: Government Policies and Interventions for Development in various sectors and Issues arising out of their Design and Implementation.

Context:

Recent debates over India’s Oscar entries have highlighted how changes in Academy Awards rules may reduce domestic gatekeeping and improve global recognition for diverse Indian cinema.

What are the Oscars?

- ❖ The Academy Awards are **among the most prestigious film awards** in the world, presented annually to honour excellence in filmmaking across different categories.
- ❖ **Winning or even being nominated** for an Oscar significantly enhances the global visibility and credibility of a film.

Best International Feature Film

- ❖ This **category is specifically meant for non-English language films** from different countries.
- ❖ Until 2020, the category was called “**Best Foreign Film,**” but it was later renamed “Best International Feature Film” to adopt a more inclusive and globally sensitive terminology.

Old Oscar Rule: “One Country, One Film”

- ❖ Under the earlier Oscar system, every country was allowed to send only one official film for consideration in the Best International Feature Film category.

Role of the Film Federation of India (FFI)

- ❖ In India, the **Film Federation of India** was responsible for selecting the country’s official Oscar entry.
- ❖ The committee had the authority to decide which single film would represent India on the global stage.

Problem of Internal Gatekeeping

Meaning of Gatekeeping

- ❖ Gatekeeping **refers to a situation where a small institution or committee controls access** to opportunities and representation.
- ❖ In the context of cinema, it means that a limited group decides which film is considered worthy of representing an entire nation.

Why This Became Problematic in India?

- ❖ India produces thousands of films every year in numerous languages such as Hindi, Tamil, Malayalam, Marathi, Telugu, Punjabi, Bhojpuri, and Bengali.
- ❖ However, no single committee can possess equal expertise in evaluating cinema from all linguistic and cultural backgrounds.

Major Concerns

- ❖ The selection process often **favoured “safe”** and non-controversial films.
- ❖ Movies **dealing with sensitive themes such as caste discrimination**, political critique, social inequality, or marginalised voices were often ignored.
- ❖ As a result, **artistically rich and internationally appreciated films frequently** failed to become India’s official Oscar entries.

Examples of Critically Acclaimed Films Overlooked:

Film	Major Themes	International Recognition	Key Issue Highlighted
The Lunchbox	Explored loneliness, emotional disconnect, and urban alienation in modern city life.	Received widespread appreciation at the Cannes Film Festival and among global critics.	Despite international acclaim, it was not selected as India’s official Oscar entry, reflecting institutional gatekeeping.
Masaan	Focused on caste realities, grief, aspiration, and social struggles in Varanasi.	Won important honours at Cannes and was praised for realistic storytelling.	Although critically acclaimed globally, it was overlooked as India’s Oscar submission.

Court	Critically examined the functioning and complexities of the Indian judicial system.	Won the prestigious Orizzonti Award at the Venice Film Festival.	The film struggled due to lack of financial support for international lobbying, marketing, and campaigning.
Village Rockstars	Depicted rural aspirations and everyday struggles through a realistic narrative.	Received critical appreciation in international film circuits.	Being a low-budget independent film, it lacked resources for a strong Oscar campaign.
All We Imagine as Light	Highlighted human relationships, migration, and urban experiences with artistic storytelling.	Gained international prestige through recognition at Cannes.	Reflected the broader issue of weak marketing, distribution, and lobbying support for independent Indian cinema.

New Oscar Pathway:

Reduced Dependence on National Committees

What Has Changed?

- ❖ Recent changes in Oscar eligibility norms have reduced complete dependence on national film committees for recognition.
- ❖ Films receiving strong appreciation at major international film festivals can now gain global visibility and Oscar momentum more directly.

Importance of International Film Festivals:

- ❖ Cannes Film Festival
- ❖ Venice Film Festival

Significance of the Change

- ❖ It **reduces institutional monopoly** over representation.
- ❖ Independent filmmakers **receive greater global exposure**.
- ❖ Regional cinema gains better opportunities for international recognition.
- ❖ Artistic quality receives more importance than bureaucratic approval.

Concerns Associated with the New System

- ❖ **Risk of “Poverty Porn”**: Some experts fear that filmmakers may deliberately exaggerate poverty, slums, and suffering in order to appeal to Western audiences and international juries.
 - This tendency is often referred to as “poverty porn.”
- ❖ Such portrayals **may distort the complexity of Indian society** and reduce the country’s image to stereotypes of deprivation and backwardness.

Homogenization vs Authenticity

- ❖ **Homogenization**: Homogenization **refers to the dilution of local cultural identity** in order to satisfy global tastes and expectations.
- ❖ There is concern that filmmakers may gradually abandon indigenous storytelling traditions and start creating films primarily to please international critics.

Importance of Authenticity

Experts argue that cinema rooted deeply in local culture, customs, and lived realities often resonates more strongly with global audiences.

Example: Parasite

- ❖ The film remained deeply connected to South Korean society and social realities.

- ❖ Despite its strong local identity, it achieved immense international success and won the Oscar for Best Picture. This demonstrates that authenticity, rather than cultural imitation, can create global impact.

Major Challenges Before Independent Indian Cinema

- ❖ **Distribution Challenges:** Many Indian independent films fail to secure widespread theatrical release or OTT distribution in foreign markets. Without global accessibility, even high-quality films remain confined to festival circuits.
- ❖ **Financial Limitations:** Independent films generally operate with very limited budgets. They often lack:
 - International marketing campaigns.
 - Lobbying networks in Hollywood.
 - Global distribution support.
 - Public relations and award-season financing.

Way Forward:

- ❖ **Institutional and Financial Support:** The government and private cultural institutions should provide dedicated financial assistance for internationally nominated Indian films. This would help filmmakers manage expensive Oscar campaigns and improve their global competitiveness.
- ❖ **Strengthening Distribution Networks:** India should invest in stronger international distribution channels so that independent and regional films can reach wider global audiences.
- ❖ **Promoting Diversity in Cinema:** Greater encouragement should be given to regional languages, local narratives, and socially relevant storytelling to ensure inclusive cultural representation.
- ❖ **Preserving Cultural Authenticity:** Indian filmmakers should focus on authentic storytelling rooted in local realities instead of attempting to imitate Western cinematic expectations.

Mains Practice:

- Q. The recent changes in the Academy Awards' International Feature Film category present an unprecedented opportunity for India's independent cinema. However, global visibility requires more than just artistic merit. Analyze. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

Ecocide and International Environmental Law

GS III: Conservation, Environmental Pollution and Degradation, Environmental Impact Assessment.

Context:

Growing environmental destruction caused by wars, industrial activities, and climate-related exploitation has revived global debates on recognising “**Ecocide**” as an international crime.

What is Ecocide?

- ❖ **Ecocide** refers to the large-scale destruction of the environment caused by human activities, particularly when such destruction is **severe, long-term, and difficult to reverse**.
- ❖ In 2021, Stop Ecocide International defined ecocide as **unlawful or reckless acts** committed with the knowledge that they are likely to cause widespread or long-term environmental damage.
- ❖ The term essentially means the “**killing of the environment**,” similar to how **genocide** refers to the mass destruction of human groups.

Historical Background of Ecocide

- ❖ **Vietnam War and Agent Orange:** One of the most prominent examples of ecocide was witnessed during the Vietnam War between the 1960s and 1970s.
- ❖ **Use of Agent Orange**
 - The **United States Government** used a chemical herbicide known as **Agent Orange** in Vietnam.

- Large forest areas were destroyed to eliminate vegetation cover.
- Agricultural land became infertile for many years.
- Exposure to toxic chemicals caused **genetic mutations** and **birth defects** across generations.
- ❖ **Arthur Galston's Concern:** Arthur Galston, whose research contributed indirectly to the development of Agent Orange, later expressed deep regret regarding its environmental and humanitarian consequences.

Emergence of the Ecocide Debate

- ❖ **Stockholm Conference, 1972:** The issue of ecocide gained international visibility during the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment held in Stockholm in 1972.
- ❖ **Role of Olof Palme** Olof Palme strongly criticised the environmental destruction caused during the Vietnam War and prominently used the term “**Ecocide**” in international discussions.
 - The conference later led to the establishment of the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP).

Timeline of Developments Related to Ecocide

Development	Significance
Coining of the term “ Ecocide ” by Arthur Galston	Drew attention to environmental destruction during wars
Stockholm Conference (1972)	Brought global recognition to environmental protection
Domestic laws in Vietnam	Attempted legal response to environmental destruction
2021 definition by Stop Ecocide International	Provided a formal legal definition
Council of Europe initiatives	Expanded recognition of ecocide in European legal discourse
Growing ICC debate	Proposal to recognise ecocide as an international crime

International Criminal Court (ICC) and Ecocide

- ❖ The International Criminal Court (ICC) was established under the Rome Statute to prosecute serious international crimes.

Existing Crimes Under ICC Jurisdiction

Currently, the ICC prosecutes four major crimes:

- ❖ **Genocide**
- ❖ **Crimes against humanity**
- ❖ **War crimes**
- ❖ **Crime of aggression**

Proposal for a Fifth Crime

- ❖ There is growing demand to include **Ecocide** as the **fifth international crime** under the ICC framework.
- ❖ Supporters argue that large-scale environmental destruction should be treated as seriously as genocide or war crimes because it threatens **ecosystems, biodiversity, and future generations**.

Environmental Protection During Armed Conflict

- ❖ **Geneva Conventions:** The Geneva Conventions regulate conduct during wars and emphasise protection of civilians and the environment during armed conflicts.
 - They discourage unnecessary **environmental destruction** during military operations.
- ❖ **ENMOD Convention, 1978:** The Environmental Modification Convention (ENMOD) prohibits the hostile use of **environmental modification techniques** during warfare.
- ❖ **Examples of Prohibited Actions**
 - Diverting rivers to destroy enemy territories

- Artificially inducing droughts or floods
- Manipulating weather systems through technologies such as **cloud seeding**

Anthropocentric vs Ecocentric Approaches

- ❖ **Anthropocentric Approach:** Current environmental laws are largely anthropocentric, meaning they focus primarily on harm caused to human beings.
 - Under this approach, environmental destruction becomes legally significant mainly when it directly harms people.
 - **Example:** If a factory releases toxic chemicals into a river and humans die or become ill, the act is treated as a crime. However, if ecosystems are damaged but no direct human harm occurs, legal accountability often remains weak.
- ❖ **Ecocentric Approach:** The **ecocentric approach** treats nature as having **intrinsic value** independent of human interests. According to this perspective:
 - Nature itself deserves protection.
 - Environmental destruction should be considered a crime even if no direct human injury occurs.
 - Ecosystems, biodiversity, forests, rivers, and wildlife possess independent ecological significance.

Limitations in Current International Law

- ❖ **Human-Centric Legal Framework:** Most existing laws focus more on human suffering than on environmental destruction itself.
- ❖ **Limitation to Wartime Situation:** Even if ecocide is recognised under the ICC, its applicability may remain limited mainly to **war-related environmental destruction**.
 - Environmental damage caused during **peacetime industrial activities** may still remain inadequately addressed.
- ❖ **Jurisdiction and Enforcement Challenges:** Not all countries are members of the ICC. Major powers such as the United States and Israel are not full participants in the ICC system.
 - As a result, enforcing international environmental accountability against powerful states remains difficult.
- ❖ **Difficulty in Amending the Rome Statute:** Any amendment to the **Rome Statute** requires approval by **two-thirds of member states**, making legal reform politically challenging.

Recent Positive Developments

- ❖ **Recognition by Environmental Organisations:** In 2025, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) recognised ecocide as a significant environmental concern, increasing **moral pressure** on states.
- ❖ **European Legal Developments:** The **Council of Europe** has also moved toward recognising serious environmental destruction as a punishable offence.
 - These developments indicate growing global acceptance of stronger **environmental accountability mechanisms**.

Importance of Recognising Ecocide

- ❖ **Environmental Protection:** Recognition of ecocide can strengthen global efforts to protect **forests, rivers, biodiversity, and ecosystems**.
- ❖ **Climate Justice:** It can promote accountability for environmental destruction contributing to **climate change** and ecological collapse.
- ❖ **Intergenerational Equity:** Ecocide laws can help safeguard the rights of **future generations** by preventing irreversible environmental damage.
- ❖ **Strengthening International Environmental Governance:** Recognition of ecocide may encourage stronger international cooperation and stricter **corporate and state accountability**.

Way Forward

- ❖ **Shift Towards Ecocentric Jurisprudence:** International environmental law should increasingly recognise nature as an entity deserving **independent legal protection**.
- ❖ **Expanding ICC Jurisdiction:** Global consensus should be built for recognising ecocide as the **fifth international crime** under the ICC.
- ❖ **Stronger Enforcement Mechanisms:** International institutions should be strengthened to ensure accountability for **large-scale environmental destruction**.
- ❖ **Greater Global Cooperation:** Countries must cooperate to create **uniform environmental standards** and improve international ecological governance.

Mains Practice:

- Q. The current international legal framework is inherently anthropocentric, falling short in prosecuting severe environmental damage during conflicts. Analyze the arguments for recognizing Ecocide as a separate crime under the Rome Statute. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

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